

Digital Intelligence and Algorithmic Animaticity: Data Indexicality, Synthetic Bodies and Embodied Viewing in AI-Generated Moving Images

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Abstract. AI-generated moving images now circulate as model demonstrations, short films, festival works and platform-native audiovisual experiments. They are often discussed through automation, copyright, deception or production efficiency, yet these frames do not fully explain how generated images become legible as moving-image culture. This article proposes algorithmic animaticity as a concept for analysing how generative AI systems produce motion, liveliness and screen-world continuity through probabilistic modelling, data-driven synthesis and human selection. Drawing on film theory, animation studies, social semiotics and digital media theory, the article examines Sora demonstrations, Air Head, The Frost, Total Pixel Space, Intracranial Garden (Lu Nei Hua Yuan) and Dang Gui (Getting Home) as symptomatic cases of generative screen culture. The analysis develops three claims. First, AI-generated moving images relocate animated intention from frame-by-frame fabrication to prompt design, model choice, iteration, editing and post-generation judgement. Second, they produce data indexicality: a mediated relation to accumulated visual archives, model training and platform interfaces rather than to a singular photographed event. Third, their synthetic bodies invite embodied viewing while unsettling ordinary trust in recorded bodily presence. The article treats digital intelligence as a cultural condition in which generative systems organise perception, agency and audiovisual trust. It contributes to digital intelligence research by offering a humanities-based vocabulary for analysing synthetic media beyond technical novelty, and by linking generative audiovisual aesthetics to disclosure, trust, institutional evaluation and visual literacy.

Keywords: artificial intelligence; AI-generated moving images; algorithmic animaticity; data indexicality; embodied viewing

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1. Introduction: AI Moving Images as Digital Intelligence Screen Culture

Generative artificial intelligence has unsettled one of the most durable assumptions in film and media studies: that moving images become intelligible through a relation among camera, world, apparatus and viewer. Classical film theory approached cinematic meaning through photographic trace, screen organisation, narrative convention and spectatorial positioning. Bazin connected film realism to automatic registration, while later debates over digital cinema examined how pixels, code and compositing altered the material status of the image [1-3]. AI-generated moving images intensify this problem because their surfaces frequently resemble photographic cinema while their conditions of production are closer to animation, database recombination and probabilistic modelling.

The problem is more than technological. Digital intelligence has become a cultural infrastructure that reorganises how images are generated, selected, circulated and evaluated. Text-to-video systems do not simply automate an old production task. They translate linguistic prompts, training data, model weights, platform interfaces and human judgement into visible movement. A generated shot may imitate camera movement, lighting contrast, human gesture and spatial depth, yet it does not necessarily correspond to a photographed event. This makes AI moving images a privileged object for analysing the relation between digital intelligence and audiovisual meaning-making.

Recent debates on AI images often cluster around automation, labour displacement, copyright, deception, creative authorship and the limits of realism. These questions remain important. Yet they do not fully explain how AI-generated moving images become meaningful as social and aesthetic signs. A video produced by a model may be technically synthetic, but it can still be read through the recognisable grammars of the cinematic shot: framing, point of view, bodily movement, lighting, spatial depth, montage and narrative expectation. The critical gap addressed here concerns the process through which generated moving images become legible, persuasive or troubling under generative media conditions.

This article asks four linked questions. First, what semiotic and aesthetic resources allow a prompt-generated video to resemble a cinematic moving image? Second, how do datasets, models, interfaces, prompts and editorial selections participate in the formation of visual meaning? Third, how do synthetic bodies invite, suspend or disturb embodied viewing?

Fourth, what does the circulation of these images through platforms and festivals suggest about digital intelligence as a cultural and technical formation?

The concept proposed here is algorithmic animaticity. The term names the mode of movement, liveliness and world-making produced when generative systems animate forms without relying primarily on photographic capture or frame-by-frame human fabrication. Algorithmic marks the computational, probabilistic and data-driven basis of the image. Animaticity points to the production of animated form, bodily movement and screen-world continuity. The concept is not a genre label. It is a vocabulary for describing how generated moving images acquire cinematic readability when their material conditions are closer to prediction, recombination and synthesis than to camera-based recording.

The article also develops data indexicality. The term does not mean that AI-generated images are indexical in the same way as photographs. Rather, it describes a mediated relation to accumulated visual archives, model training, platform interfaces and human selections. A generated street, face, landscape or gesture may not point to a singular profilmic event, but it still points to historical visual patterns that have become learnable and reproducible. This dispersed relation to visual history is central to the ontology of AI-generated moving images. The contribution is threefold. Conceptually, the article defines algorithmic animaticity as a cultural-aesthetic condition of digital intelligence rather than as a synonym for AI animation. Methodologically, it shows how close reading can still operate in relation to AI-generated images, provided that analysis moves across visible form, paratext, interface and production discourse. Practically, it links generative audiovisual aesthetics to questions of disclosure, trust, digital literacy and institutional evaluation. The article treats digital intelligence not as a computational property alone, but as a cultural condition in which generative systems organise perception, agency and audiovisual trust. This humanities-based approach complements technical studies of model performance by asking how generated outputs become socially legible and institutionally valuable.

2. Materials and Methods

The study uses qualitative close reading combined with attention to technological and institutional paratexts. It is interpretive and conceptual rather than quantitative. The analysis does not evaluate model performance through benchmark metrics. Instead, it asks how generated moving images organise perception, affect, trust and cinematic readability. Shots are analysed in relation to movement, framing, spatial continuity, bodily gesture, texture,

rhythm, atmosphere and viewer address. Because the objects are AI-generated, close reading is extended to include prompts, platform descriptions, festival contexts and production statements where these materials are publicly available.

This method draws on social semiotics and multimodal analysis. Social semiotics treats signs as socially organised resources rather than neutral containers of meaning [4-7]. Multimodal analysis attends to how image, movement, sound, writing, interface, gesture and spatial organisation work together [8-10]. In the case of AI moving images, this combined method is necessary because the image rarely arrives alone. It is framed by software interfaces, prompts, platform announcements, technical demonstrations, captions, music, voice-over, editing and festival categories. These paratexts are not secondary decorations. They teach viewers how to interpret the generated image.

The corpus is purposive and theoretically driven. It includes public AI video demonstrations and short films that have circulated as reference points in debates on generative moving images: OpenAI's Sora demonstrations and related creator examples, including Air Head [21, 22]; The Frost, first released by Waymark in 2023 and later circulated through Latent Cinema materials [23, 28]; Total Pixel Space, discussed in relation to Runway's AI Festival and platform-based AI moving-image culture [24]; Intracranial Garden (Lu Nei Hua Yuan), recognised in the AIGC short-film section of the Beijing International Film Festival [25, 26]; and Dang Gui (Getting Home), discussed through HKUST AI film materials [27].

Case	Year	Source / institution	Format	AI relation	Analytical focus
Sora demonstrations	2024	OpenAI [21]	Model demonstration	Text-to-video system demonstration	World simulation; platform paratext; cinematic plausibility
Air Head	2024	Shy Kids / Sora [22]	Short film	Sora-assisted production	Synthetic body; surreal figure; narrative stabilisation
The Frost	2023/2024	Waymark / Latent Cinema [23, 28]	Short film	AI-generated imagery with human editing	Multimodal cohesion; sequencing; post-generation judgement
Total Pixel Space	2025	Runway AIFF 2025 [24]	Festival short	AI festival work	Latent-space aesthetics; institutional recognition
Intracranial Garden (Lu Nei Hua Yuan)	2024	BJIFF AIGC / China Academy of Art [25, 26]	Festival-recognised student work	3D scanning; AI-generated imagery; point-cloud visualisation	Memory; interiority; spatial reconstruction
Dang Gui (Getting Home)	2025	HKUST AI Film Festival [27]	Award-winning AI short	AI-generated festival work	Homecoming; war memory; cultural affect

The table does not treat the six cases as a statistically representative sample. It clarifies the comparative logic of the close readings: each case is used because it foregrounds a different relation among digital intelligence, moving-image form, institutional framing and embodied viewing.

The cases were selected according to three criteria. First, they have public visibility and institutional circulation. They are not private experiments but works, demonstrations or festival examples that have entered public discourse. Second, they explicitly involve generative AI or AI video systems, making them relevant to algorithmic moving-image production rather than ordinary digital post-production. Third, they engage cinematic resources such as framing, motion, narrative, body, atmosphere or world-making. The aim is not to produce a comprehensive map of AI film, which would be premature in a rapidly changing field. The aim is to analyse a set of symptomatic examples that reveal different operations of AI-generated screen culture.

The analysis distinguishes between three levels of evidence. The first level is textual: what the image shows, how it moves and how it organises bodies and spaces. The second level is paratextual: how the work is titled, described, exhibited, promoted or evaluated. The third

level is infrastructural: what the case reveals about datasets, model systems, platforms and production workflows. The article moves across these levels because AI moving images become meaningful through their interaction. A generated shot may look cinematic, but its interpretation changes when it is presented as a model demonstration, an experimental film, a festival entry or a proof of technical capacity.

The study has two limitations. It cannot empirically measure audience reception, and it does not adjudicate copyright claims attached to training data. Both topics deserve separate investigation. The present article treats ethics through ontology and semiosis: it asks how the data-driven formation of images changes the relation among material substrate, agency, body and meaning. This choice does not bracket politics. It places politics inside the analysis of visual materiality and meaning-making, where questions of visibility, bias and cultural memory become inseparable from the generation of signs [17-20].

3. Conceptual Framework

3.1 Digital Intelligence and Generative Screen Systems

Digital intelligence is often discussed as a capacity for algorithmic analysis, prediction, optimisation and human-machine collaboration. In audiovisual culture, however, digital intelligence is not simply a back-end capability. It becomes visible as a mode of image formation. A generative video system translates prompts, reference images, model parameters and learned visual correlations into moving-image outputs. This process makes intelligence appear as screen form: a camera-like movement, a plausible atmosphere, a coherent body, an apparent causal world or a genre-coded mood.

This visible intelligence is culturally mediated. No model works from neutral data. It works from histories of image-making, from the defaults built into platforms and interfaces, and from the prompt habits and expectations users bring to it. A request for a cinematic close-up, a handheld street scene or a dreamlike animation has already called up visual categories that people learned socially. The interface here is a semiotic technology. It limits what a user can ask for. It shapes how an output is previewed. And it decides which images get kept and which get thrown away [11].

The phrase AI-generated screen culture means more than using AI to make media. It points to a situation in which computational systems help to choose and arrange audiovisual signs. Language becomes visual possibility once it passes through a prompt, and the user who writes

that prompt is really designing the conditions under which meaning will appear. Behind this sit the datasets that turn old archives into generative material and the platforms that send finished outputs out for sharing. Festivals and awards enter late, treating novelty as cultural value. What a generated moving image finally means to a public is decided across all of these stages, not at any single one.

3.2 Algorithmic Animaticity

Animation theory is indispensable here, because animation has long unsettled the assumption that screen movement must rest on photographic registration. For Wells, animation's strength lay in its capacity to construct bodies and worlds that exceed photographic realism [12]; Buchan went further, treating animation as something pervasive across contemporary media rather than a discrete genre [13]. Lamarre, in turn, clarifies how movement can be organised through layers, compositing and technical mediation [14]. AI-generated video pushes these questions on another step, since it produces both form and motion from statistical inference, not from hand-drawn, stop-motion or fully controlled computer-animation pipelines.

Algorithmic animaticity works along five dimensions that overlap in practice. Generativity is the most basic: images are inferred, not captured. Plasticity is the ease with which characters, objects, textures and atmospheres can be reshaped. Movement here is a matter of prediction, interpolation and sampling, not of a continuous recorded take. Worldhood is the holding-together of environments, styles and causal cues into something coherent. And non-photographic indexicality, the fifth, is what cuts the moving image loose from any one recorded event. This does not turn AI film into animation. It does mean that AI moving images take animation's constructive logic and put it to work inside probabilistic systems.

The term is useful because it avoids two reductive accounts. One account treats AI video as a simple technical upgrade in production workflow, as if the primary question were speed, cost or automation. Another account treats AI video as a threat to cinematic authenticity and returns too quickly to a nostalgic model of photographic truth. Algorithmic animaticity instead describes a new organisation of visual resources. AI-generated moving images borrow from photographic realism, animation, digital compositing and platform culture, but their visible meaning emerges from a distinctive configuration of these elements.

This configuration also changes modality. Visual modality refers to the socially learned judgement that an image appears more or less credible, naturalistic, authoritative or fictional [6]. AI-generated moving images can produce high-modality cues - recognisable skin texture, atmospheric lighting, lens blur, camera movement and plausible spatial depth - without the

photographic relation that historically supported those cues. Viewers are asked to read modality from surface coherence, institutional framing and disclosure rather than from assumed capture. The result is a double viewing attitude: immersion in the image and inspection of its generated condition.

3.3 Data Indexicality

The problem of indexicality has long structured film theory. Bazin's account of the photographic image placed cinema in relation to automatic registration and the preservation of the world [1]. Later debates complicated this claim by showing how cinematic realism depends on convention, institution, narrative and spectatorship as well as photographic inscription [2, 3]. AI-generated moving images intensify this historical problem because they can produce the look of a photographed world without requiring a photographed scene.

Data indexicality names this displacement. The concept does not mean that AI images have no relation to reality. They are intensely related to reality through the historical accumulation of visual culture. Datasets contain traces of cameras, artists, platforms, archives, genres, advertising images, stock photography, animation, amateur video and cinematic convention. A generated image is not outside history. It is saturated with history. Its indexical force, however, is dispersed across data and model training rather than concentrated in the moment of capture. The generated image points back to a visual archive and a technical process instead of pointing directly to a photographed referent.

This is why AI moving images can be both convincing and unstable. They inherit the visual plausibility of photographic and cinematic conventions while severing those conventions from the event-based relation that traditionally anchored viewerly trust. A shot of a woman walking through snow, a creature moving beside a candle or a balloon-headed man in a domestic space may appear cinematically legible because viewers recognise bodies, depth, lighting, framing and motion. The image asks to be viewed through the habits of cinema. At the same time, viewers may know that no such event was recorded. Belief becomes a perceptual and institutional effect rather than a documentary relation.

Data indexicality also clarifies why AI images are never merely synthetic in a simple sense. Their bodies, faces, gestures and settings are generated from the sedimented patterns of older visual regimes. Work on AI infrastructures has shown that computational systems are shaped by histories of data extraction, classification and uneven representation [17-20]. In audiovisual terms, this means that the dataset can be treated as a material substrate. It

constrains possible forms, weights some visual patterns more heavily than others and determines which types of body, setting or action are more likely to appear plausible.

4. Case Analysis: Algorithmic Animaticity in Practice

4.1 Model Demonstration and Platform Discourse: Sora and Runway

Sora's demonstration videos provide a clear example of how algorithmic animaticity becomes socially legible. The demonstrations use recognisable cinematic resources: tracking movement, shallow depth of field, street textures, light reflections, crowded spaces and plausible bodily motion. OpenAI described Sora as a generalist model of visual data capable of generating videos across durations, aspect ratios and resolutions, and framed video generation in relation to world simulation [21]. This claim is itself part of the paratext. It asks viewers to see the generated videos as attractive moving images and as signs of a model's capacity to infer physical and temporal relations.

The demonstrations imitate camera intentionality. The simulated camera seems to know where to move, how long to hold a subject and how to preserve a plausible relation between figure and ground. This apparent intention emerges from the model's learned grammar of cinematography. Yet it remains unstable. AI-generated movement can expose uncertain physics, inconsistent spatial relations or slight disturbances in bodily balance. The semiotic effect is doubled: the image borrows cinematic authority while inviting inspection of its generated condition. Viewers admire the shot and search for failure at the same time.

This double viewing structure is not a marginal problem. It belongs to the cultural form of digital intelligence. When a model demonstration is circulated, its image is read as aesthetic output and technical proof. A beautiful generated shot is never only a shot. It is also evidence of model capacity, platform strategy and future production promise. Platform discourse participates in the meaning of the image. It directs the viewer toward intelligence, capability, scalability and world modelling.

Runway's AI Festival extends this platform discourse into an institutional field [24]. A festival does not merely display AI outputs. It supplies categories, awards, screening contexts and evaluative language through which generated moving images can be recognised as creative works. This matters because institutions help stabilise new semiotic resources. A generated sequence becomes a film partly through the public processes that name it, programme it,

reward it and invite audiences to judge it through cinematic criteria. The platform participates in the making of cinematic legitimacy.

Total Pixel Space is useful because it treats the possibility space of the generated image reflexively. Instead of hiding the computational condition behind ordinary cinematic illusion, it foregrounds pixel space as a field of transformation and abstraction. In this case, algorithmic animaticity appears less as imitation of camera realism and more as display of generative plasticity. The image calls attention to the mutability of visual matter. Such work shows that AI film does not need to move only toward photorealism. It can also make instability, abstraction and latent-space transformation into aesthetic resources.

4.2 Narrative Stabilisation: Air Head and The Frost

Air Head foregrounds algorithmic animaticity through fantasy. The figure of a person with a balloon-like head moving through everyday environments belongs to a long tradition of surreal comedy and animated metamorphosis. What matters here is that the impossible body is rendered with a plausible cinematic surface. The viewer can read the image through familiar resources: character-centred framing, comic incongruity, everyday mise-en-scene and the contrast between ordinary bodily gesture and impossible morphology. The body is unreal, but the scene asks to be read through the social grammar of a short film.

This case demonstrates why AI-generated moving images cannot be understood only through the question of realism. The balloon-headed figure is not realistic, but it is coherent as a cinematic sign. It carries narrative expectation, emotional tone and bodily rhythm. The generated image works through a mixed modality: animation-like transformation is embedded in live-action surface cues. The viewer does not need to believe that the body existed before the camera. The viewer needs only to accept the internal rules of the screen world long enough for affect and story to operate.

The Frost shifts attention from single-shot plausibility to narrative cohesion. First released by Waymark in 2023 as a 12-minute AI-assisted short and later circulated through Latent Cinema materials, the project uses AI-generated imagery and human editorial construction to organise generated images into a story world [23, 28]. Shortfilm.de describes the early workflow as involving DALL-E 2 images and D-ID animation, which makes clear why post-generation sequencing, sound and editing matter [28]. The issue is not whether a single frame looks realistic. The more demanding problem is whether characters, environments, tone and narrative expectation remain readable across cuts. The film uses voice, music, editing rhythm and genre atmosphere to stabilise its generated materials. It shows that algorithmic animaticity

becomes cinematic when generated fragments are organised into temporal and affective sequence.

This point is crucial for digital intelligence research. AI video systems generate visual material, but filmic meaning usually emerges after selection, sequencing and sound design. The generated frame is only one component of a larger audiovisual assemblage. Editing, music, voice-over and captions guide viewers toward coherence. A sequence may survive minor visual inconsistencies because the narrative and sonic design provide interpretive continuity. AI film is rarely a pure model output. It is a collaboration among model generation, human selection and conventional audiovisual organisation.

The relocation of animated intention is visible here. In traditional animation, the maker may directly control line, colour, movement and timing. In AI film, part of that control is transferred to prompt work, model choice, repeated generation, selection and editing. The authorial act often lies in deciding which generated image becomes meaningful and which is discarded. This does not erase human agency. It changes the location of agency. Authorship becomes responsibility for design, curation and disclosure rather than total control over every visible mark.

4.3 Chinese-Language Festival and Educational Contexts: Intracranial Garden (Lu Nei Hua Yuan) and Dang Gui (Getting Home)

Chinese-language cases add an important layer because they move the discussion beyond a narrow Silicon Valley account of generative video. Intracranial Garden (Lu Nei Hua Yuan) is significant because its recognition within the Beijing International Film Festival AIGC short-film section places AI imagery within an institutional film culture rather than a purely technological showcase [25, 26]. China Academy of Art, the home institution of director Yan Xiangning, reports that the work won the Best Visual Effects Award while using 3D scanning, AI-generated imagery and point-cloud technology [25]. The work turns memory into a reconstructed spatial field. Its scanned and point-cloud spaces make recollection appear as a fragile audiovisual environment: the mind is not represented as a stable container, but as a partially rebuilt scene in which home, history and identity are assembled through data, voice and visual metaphor. Read through algorithmic animaticity, the work matters because it translates inner life into a synthetic moving-image space that still asks to be read cinematically.

The Beijing International Film Festival AIGC section also shows how AI-generated moving images are being institutionally normalised. Such a section does more than recognise works

after they exist. It defines a field of expectation: what counts as AIGC film, what kinds of innovation are rewarded, how technical novelty is linked to cinematic expression and how young creators are invited to position themselves within a new industrial horizon. Digital intelligence enters film culture through software and through awards, educational institutions, media reports and professional networks.

This institutional translation matters. In Chinese-language contexts, AI film is often framed in relation to industrial transformation, educational innovation, youth creativity and technological upgrading. These frames may differ from Western debates that focus on copyright, labour and authenticity. The difference should not be overstated, but it reminds us that algorithmic animaticity is always socially situated. A generated image may share similar technical conditions across countries, yet its public meaning changes when it is attached to different institutions, policy discourses and creative training systems.

Dang Gui (Getting Home) points in a different direction. HKUST describes YE Zhixiang's film as following a war veteran across a half-century journey home, and notes that it took both the Best Narrative Award and the Viewer's Choice Award at the HKUST AI Film Festival [27]. There is a double resonance in the Chinese title: Dang Gui can be heard as 'should return', yet it also evokes danggui, the medicinal angelica root long tied to bodily replenishment and repair. Photorealism alone is not where the film's cultural force lies. What carries it is whether synthetic bodies, aged faces, remembered places and the movement homeward can be drawn together into an affective structure of return. Here digital intelligence works on two levels at once, as an engine of visual generation and as a mediator of memory, injury and emotional recognition.

The cases pull the argument outward in two ways. One is institutional: AI-generated moving images are now entering festival and educational systems, where they are judged as creative and cultural artefacts rather than as technical demonstrations. The other concerns data indexicality, which turns out to carry a local dimension. Generated images may draw on global visual archives, yet they are read through regional genres, languages, institutions and memories. Any full account, then, has to hold technical analysis together with cultural and institutional specificity.

4.4 Synthetic Bodies and Embodied Viewing

Of everything in the corpus, the quasi-animated body is the most delicate matter. Classical screen performance rests on the recorded presence of a body that performs, however much acting style, editing and mise-en-scene mediate it. Cinema, as embodiment theorists have

argued, reaches the spectator through sensation, movement, affect and bodily memory [15, 16]. AI-generated bodies unsettle that relation. They can simulate a facial expression, a posture, a movement, and still carry none of the experiential continuity a living performer brings. What appears can be wholly persuasive while lacking any history of fatigue, breathing, hesitation or risk.

What follows is a crisis of embodied viewing. Viewers still respond to expressions, gestures and patterns of movement; affect does not switch off simply because the body on screen is synthetic. Bodily trust, though, grows unstable. A synthetic face may be made to carry grief, age, trauma or memory, and a synthetic body may seem to suffer although no living body underwent the suffering it shows. This does not render the image unethical in itself. It does shift the ground on which we watch, leaving spectators to negotiate between affective recognition and genuine uncertainty about whether any body was there at all.

I call this condition embodied suspension. The body seems present even as its lived basis stays unclear; it solicits a response while withholding the ordinary assurance that would ground one. Animated embodiment is not quite the same, since there the viewer generally knows from the outset that the character has been drawn, modelled or otherwise built. AI-generated bodies are trickier, because they take on the modality cues of photographic bodies while being produced much as animation is. The ethical ambiguity sits precisely in that overlap, where a face can move us at the very moment we doubt the bodily history behind it. This is also why viewers keep scrutinising hands, eyes, shadows, joints and gestures in AI-generated video. Such details turn into diagnostic sites. Far from being mere technical slips, they are the places where the body is made to prove itself: a miscounted finger, an odd turn of the wrist, a facial transition that will not settle, any of these can betray the missing continuity of a lived body. Watching becomes forensic. And that forensic attention is, in itself, a new visual literacy belonging to digital intelligence.

5. Discussion: Agency, Trust and Governance in Generative Screen Culture

5.1 Distributed Semiotic Agency

The cases show that AI-generated moving images make sign-making visibly distributed. Human creators design prompts, choose models, select outputs and organise sequences. Platforms define available tools, defaults and styles. Datasets transmit prior visual decisions.

Algorithms generate possibilities. Audiences interpret the result through existing visual literacies. Agency is not purely human or machinic; it is configured across a network of resources and institutions. This does not mean that responsibility vanishes. On the contrary, the distribution of agency makes responsibility more important.

Prompting is a useful example. A prompt is not a transparent command. It is a semiotic design device that translates intention into a form the model can process. Prompting draws on genre labels, visual adjectives, camera terminology, art-historical references, emotional cues and platform-specific conventions. It is closer to multimodal design than to ordinary instruction. A phrase such as cinematic night street, documentary close-up or dreamlike childhood memory activates socially learned patterns. Digital intelligence depends on human cultural knowledge even when the output is generated computationally.

The authorial question should be reframed accordingly. Asking whether the human or the machine is the author oversimplifies the problem. The sharper question is how semiotic agency is distributed and where responsibility for meaning is located. A creator may not fully know how a specific visual solution emerges, yet still selects, edits and circulates it. A platform may not author a particular sequence, yet it shapes available styles and interface affordances. A dataset may not intend a representation, yet it conditions which bodies and settings become probable. Digital intelligence requires an ethics of design, curation and disclosure.

5.2 Trust, Labelling and Visual Literacy

The problem of trust follows from data indexicality. In photographic culture, trust often depended on assumptions about capture, witness and manipulation. In AI image culture, trust depends increasingly on disclosure, context, consistency and institutional framing. A generated image may be trustworthy as fiction, art or speculative design if its status is clear. It may be untrustworthy as evidence if it hides its generated basis. Trust should be analysed not as a simple property of the image but as a relation among form, context, genre and viewer expectation.

This has practical implications for AI-generated moving images. Labelling should not be treated only as a regulatory burden. It is part of the semiotic frame that allows audiences to interpret the image appropriately. A clear disclosure can shift the viewer from documentary expectation to speculative or artistic expectation. It can also protect creators by making the production status of the work legible. In the context of festivals, education and platform

circulation, disclosure should be accompanied by basic information about tools, production process, human editing and the status of any source footage or reference images.

Visual literacy also needs to change. Viewers of AI-generated media must learn to read both screen form and production condition. They need to understand how a generated shot can look realistic without being evidentiary, how a synthetic body can produce affect without recorded presence and how platform discourse can frame technical novelty as cultural value. This does not mean teaching viewers to distrust all images. It means teaching them to distinguish genres of trust: fiction, speculation, demonstration, evidence, documentation, advertising and artistic experiment.

These distinctions matter for digital intelligence governance. Technical watermarking and metadata may help, but they do not replace cultural literacy. A watermark tells viewers that a file may be generated. It does not explain how to interpret an image's affective force, narrative function or institutional frame. Digital intelligence research needs to combine technical safeguards with humanities-based analysis of meaning, body and context. AI-generated moving images are more than outputs to be detected; they are cultural signs to be read.

5.3 Contribution to Digital Intelligence Research

The article contributes to digital intelligence research by showing that generative systems should be analysed through computational capacity and their cultural forms of intelligibility. Sora demonstrations, AI short films and AIGC festival works are not simply examples of model progress. They are public scenes in which intelligence is made visible, evaluated and imagined. The viewer learns what digital intelligence is by watching what it appears to make possible: a moving street, a fantasy body, a memory space, a coherent atmosphere, a narrative sequence or an abstract image field.

This emphasis changes the research agenda. Instead of asking only how accurately a model can generate video, scholars should also ask how generated videos organise modality, affect, agency and trust. Instead of asking only whether AI film will replace existing production labour, they should ask how creative labour is redistributed across prompt work, selection, iteration, editing and disclosure. Instead of asking only whether generated images are real or fake, they should ask what kind of indexical relation they establish with data, archives and cultural memory.

The article also suggests that digital intelligence is more than computational intelligence. It is a socio-technical arrangement in which computational systems interact with human

judgement, institutional framing and cultural expectation. AI-generated moving images make this arrangement visible because their screen surfaces appear familiar while their material basis is transformed. They ask viewers to reconsider what makes a shot cinematic, what makes a body affective and what makes an image trustworthy. They deserve attention because they show how artificial intelligence enters ordinary perception as infrastructure, body, image, motion, narrative and institutional value.

6. Limitations and Future Research

This article is conceptual and interpretive. It does not measure audience responses, compare model architectures or conduct interviews with creators. Future research can extend the argument in at least four directions. First, reception studies could examine how different audiences interpret AI-generated moving images, including whether they experience the same image as film, demonstration, deception or art. Second, production studies could investigate how creators actually negotiate prompts, model constraints, costs, copyright concerns and post-production decisions. Third, comparative cultural studies could examine how AI film is framed differently across countries, festivals and educational systems. Fourth, technical-humanities collaboration could connect model documentation with close analysis of generated image form.

There is also a need for more precise terminology around the synthetic body. Terms such as avatar, deepfake, virtual human, AI actor, synthetic performer and generated character are often used inconsistently. Algorithmic animaticity offers one vocabulary, but further work is needed to distinguish among different production pipelines and degrees of human control. A fully generated body, a motion-captured body, a digitally de-aged actor and a prompt-generated face all raise related but different questions of embodiment, consent, labour and spectatorship.

Finally, research on AI moving images must remain historically grounded. Generative video feels new, but it also inherits long histories of animation, visual effects, digital compositing, database cinema, synthetic performance and platform aesthetics. The value of concepts such as algorithmic animaticity and data indexicality is that they connect novelty to history. They help avoid both technological hype and nostalgic rejection. AI-generated moving images extend older media problems while changing the material conditions under which those problems now appear.

7. Conclusion

This article has argued that AI-generated moving images should be understood through algorithmic animaticity: a generative screen condition in which form, motion, body and world are generated through the interaction of datasets, models, prompts, platforms, human selection and embodied viewing. The concept is useful because it avoids treating AI film as either a simple continuation of cinema or a complete break from moving-image history. AI film borrows from photographic realism, animation, digital compositing and platform culture, but its meaning emerges from a distinctive configuration of these resources.

The article has also proposed data indexicality as a way to describe the material relation between generated images and visual history. The cinematic shot is no longer only captured, staged or digitally composited. It can be sampled from a latent space and made legible through familiar grammars of framing, movement, performance and world-making. Animated intention is no longer located only in the hand that draws or the body that performs. It is distributed across prompts, model systems, datasets, editorial judgement and institutional framing. Synthetic bodies continue to invite affect, but they do so while suspending ordinary trust in recorded bodily continuity.

AI-generated moving images require a theory of how images become meaningful when their material base is data, their formation is probabilistic and their bodies are synthetic yet affectively persuasive. Algorithmic animaticity offers one path for such a theory. It shows that future research on digital intelligence should not separate ontology from interpretation, materiality from spectatorship or technology from social meaning. The central problem is how generative AI systems reorganise the conditions under which visual signs can be designed, trusted, felt and circulated.

For digital intelligence research the stakes here are not hard to state. AI-generated moving images are no marginal curiosity. They are among the first public forms in which digital intelligence becomes visible, arguable and affectively persuasive, and attending to them helps show how artificial intelligence enters ordinary perception, creative labour, institutional legitimacy and audiovisual trust. The frontier, on this view, is not only a matter of building better generation models. It lies just as much in our cultural and ethical grasp of what those models make visible.

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Ethics Statement

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